SENIORS AUDIT

# Your Social Security Claiming Decision Workbook

*A step-by-step guide to deciding when to claim — using your own numbers, not a stranger's example*

Version 2026.3 • Last reviewed September 2026

seniorsaudit.com

GETTING ORIENTED

# What This Workbook Helps You Decide

This workbook helps you answer one question: When should I claim Social Security retirement benefits — at 62, at my Full Retirement Age (FRA), at 70, or somewhere in between? You can claim as early as 62 or as late as 70. The age you choose permanently changes your monthly check for the rest of your life. There is no single "right" age — it depends on your health, your other income, whether you're married, and how long you expect to need this income.

**START HERE**

This workbook uses the free Seniors Audit Full Retirement Age Calculator as its starting point. If you haven't already, run your numbers there first: seniorsaudit.com/tools/social-security-full-retirement-age-calculator

## Who this is for

- ☐ You're within about 5 years of claiming Social Security, or already eligible
- ☐ You want to understand the trade-offs before you decide, not after
- ☐ You want the actual math, not a generic rule of thumb

## Who should also talk to a professional

- ☐ You're recently divorced and unsure about ex-spouse benefit eligibility
- ☐ You have a serious health diagnosis that significantly affects life expectancy planning
- ☐ Your household has unusually large investment or business income
- ☐ You have a pension from non-covered work and want to confirm it reflects the 2025 WEP/GPO repeal (see Page 9)

GETTING ORIENTED

# Before You Begin

Gather these three things — it takes about 10 minutes and makes every worksheet in this book far more accurate:

- ☐ Your exact birth date (month, day, year)
- ☐ Your estimated monthly benefit at Full Retirement Age — from your mySocialSecurity account (ssa.gov/myaccount) or your latest paper Social Security Statement
- ☐ If married: your spouse's birth date and estimated benefit too

> **NO ACCOUNT YET?**
>
> Create one free at ssa.gov/myaccount. It takes about 10 minutes and gives you your real, personalized benefit estimate — not a generic average.

STEP 1 OF 6

# Find Your Full Retirement Age

Your Full Retirement Age (FRA) is the age at which Social Security pays your full, uncalculated benefit — no reduction, no bonus. It depends only on your birth year.

| If you were born | Your Full Retirement Age |
|---|---|
| 1943 – 1954 | 66 |
| 1955 | 66 and 2 months |
| 1956 | 66 and 4 months |
| 1957 | 66 and 6 months |
| 1958 | 66 and 8 months |
| 1959 | 66 and 10 months |
| 1960 or later | 67 |

*Source: Social Security Administration, ssa.gov/benefits/retirement/planner/agereduction.html*

**My birth year:** _____ **My Full Retirement Age:** _____

STEP 2 OF 6

# How Claiming Age Changes Your Check

Claiming before your FRA permanently reduces your benefit. Claiming after your FRA (up to age 70) permanently increases it through delayed retirement credits. This table shows the percentage of your full FRA benefit you'd receive at each claiming age, for someone with an FRA of 67 (anyone born 1960 or later):

| Claim at age | % of your FRA benefit | Compared to FRA |
|---|---|---|
| 62 | 70% | −30% permanently |
| 63 | 75% | −25% permanently |
| 64 | 80% | −20% permanently |
| 65 | 86.7% | −13.3% permanently |
| 66 | 93.3% | −6.7% permanently |
| **67 (FRA)** | **100%** | **Full benefit** |
| 68 | 108% | +8% permanently |
| 69 | 116% | +16% permanently |
| 70 | 124% | +24% permanently (max) |

*Source: SSA — early claiming reduces benefits 5/9 of 1% per month for the first 36 months before FRA, then 5/12 of 1% per month beyond that. Delayed credits add 2/3 of 1% (8%/year) per month past FRA, up to 70.*

STEP 2 OF 6 — CONTINUED

# Worked Example — Maria

Maria was born in 1962. Her FRA is 67, and her estimated benefit at FRA is $2,000/month.

| Claim at age | Monthly benefit |
|---|---|
| 62 | $1,400 |
| 67 (FRA) | $2,000 |
| **70** | **$2,480** |

> **MARIA'S DECISION**
>
> The difference between claiming at 62 and 70 is $1,080 per month, for life. That's the size of the decision this workbook helps you make with your own numbers.

## Now do your own math

**My estimated benefit at FRA (from mySocialSecurity):** _____

**My benefit at 62 (FRA amount × 0.70):** _____

**My benefit at 70 (FRA amount × 1.24):** _____

STEP 3 OF 6

# The Break-Even Question

Claiming early means smaller checks, but more of them. Claiming late means bigger checks, but fewer of them. The "break-even age" is the age at which the total money received from claiming later catches up to — and then passes — the total from claiming early. This tells you how long you'd need to live past a given age for delaying to pay off in total dollars received.

## Maria's break-even example (62 vs. 67)

Claiming at 62: $1,400/month × 60 months (5-year head start) = $84,000 received by 67. Claiming at 67 pays $600/month more ($2,000 vs. $1,400). $84,000 ÷ $600 = 140 months = 11 years 8 months past 67 — so Maria's break-even age is about **78 years and 8 months**. If she expects to live meaningfully past that, waiting until 67 pays more in total.

> **A STARTING POINT, NOT A PREDICTION**
>
> Break-even age is a starting point for thinking, not a prediction of how long you'll live. Many people weight guaranteed, inflation-protected income (via annual COLA) just as heavily. This simple math also ignores what you could earn by investing an early benefit instead of spending it — investing shifts the "delay wins" age later.

## Your break-even worksheet

**My benefit at 62:** _____ **My benefit at FRA:** _____ **My benefit at 70:** _____

*Free Seniors Audit Break-Even Calculator: seniorsaudit.com/tools/social-security-break-even-calculator*

STEP 4 OF 6

# Married? Spousal Benefits

If you're married, your claiming decision affects more than your own check. Spousal benefits are the first piece:

- ☐ A spouse can receive up to 50% of the other spouse's FRA benefit if that's more than their own — but only if the receiving spouse waits until their own FRA to claim it. Claiming the spousal benefit early permanently reduces it too (to as little as about 32.5% at 62).
- ☐ Spousal benefits do NOT receive delayed retirement credits — waiting past your own FRA doesn't increase a spousal benefit.
- ☐ "Deemed filing" means that if you were born on or after January 2, 1954, filing for one benefit (your own or spousal) generally files for both automatically — you receive whichever is higher, not a spousal check now plus your own grown later. The old "restricted application" strategy no longer works for almost anyone claiming today.
- ☐ The higher earner's claiming age has an outsized effect on the couple's total lifetime income.

**WHEN TO GET HELP**

Spousal rules have real complexity, especially with divorce, remarriage, or multiple periods of marriage. If any of these apply to you, a free SHIP counselor or a fee-only financial planner is worth the conversation before you file.

**My spouse's birth year:** _____

**Spouse's estimated FRA benefit:** _____

☐ The higher earner in our household is: ☐ Me ☐ Spouse ☐ Equal

STEP 4 OF 6 — CONTINUED

# Survivor Benefits & the WEP/GPO Update

## Survivor benefits

- ☐ When one spouse dies, the surviving spouse can switch to the deceased spouse's benefit if it's higher.
- ☐ The higher earner delaying their claim can mean a larger survivor benefit for the other spouse later — even if the higher earner doesn't personally live long enough to break even.
- ☐ One strategy still works: deemed filing does NOT apply to survivor benefits. A widow(er) can claim a survivor benefit as early as 60 and switch to their own retirement benefit later (or the reverse), whichever ends up larger.

> **UPDATE: WEP AND GPO WERE REPEALED**
>
> The Windfall Elimination Provision and Government Pension Offset — which used to reduce benefits for people with a pension from work not covered by Social Security — were fully repealed by the Social Security Fairness Act, signed January 5, 2025, retroactive to January 2024. If this affected you or your spouse, SSA should have recalculated the benefit and issued back pay. If you haven't seen that reflected, check your mySocialSecurity account or call SSA.

STEP 5 OF 6

# Still Working? The Earnings Test

If you claim Social Security before your FRA and continue working, part of your benefit may be temporarily withheld if your earnings are above the annual limit.

| Situation (2026) | Annual limit | Withholding rule |
|---|---|---|
| Under FRA all year | $24,480 | $1 withheld for every $2 earned over the limit |
| Reaching FRA in 2026 | $65,160 | $1 withheld for every $3 earned over the limit (months before FRA only) |
| **At FRA or older** | **No limit** | **Keep every dollar, no withholding** |

*Source: Social Security Administration, ssa.gov/news/en/cola/index.html (2026 COLA fact sheet)*

**NOT LOST FOREVER**

This money isn't lost forever. Once you reach FRA, Social Security recalculates your benefit going forward to credit back the months that were withheld. It's a timing issue, not a permanent penalty — but it matters for your cash flow planning right now.

**My expected earnings this year (if working):** _____

☐ Am I under my applicable limit? ☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not applicable

STEP 6 OF 6

# Your Decision Worksheet

Bring together everything from Steps 1–5 into one page.

| | Age 62 | My FRA | Age 70 |
|---|---|---|---|
| Monthly benefit | | | |
| Annual benefit | | | |
| Years until break-even vs. this option | — | | |

## Considerations checklist — check any that apply to you

- ☐ I expect to need this income soon regardless of the reduction
- ☐ I have other retirement income (pension, savings, 401(k)/IRA) that could bridge a delay
- ☐ I'm in good health with family longevity history past 80
- ☐ I have health concerns that make a longer delay feel riskier
- ☐ I'm married and want to consider the survivor benefit impact
- ☐ I'm still working and need to check the earnings test
- ☐ I want guaranteed, inflation-protected income for as long as possible

**WEIGHTING GUIDE — DON'T SKIP THIS**

Count your checkmarks: if most fall in the first group (need income now, health concerns, no other income), claiming earlier likely fits your situation better. If most fall in the second group (other income available, good health/longevity history, want maximum guaranteed income), delaying likely serves you better. If your checks split evenly, that's a strong signal this is exactly the kind of close call worth a professional conversation before deciding.

STEP 6 OF 6 — CONTINUED

# Worked Example — Maria's Worksheet

| | Age 62 | Age 67 (FRA) | Age 70 |
|---|---|---|---|
| Monthly benefit | $1,400 | $2,000 | $2,480 |
| Annual benefit | $16,800 | $24,000 | $29,760 |
| Years until break-even vs. 62 | — | ~11.7 years (age 78.7) | ~10.4 years (age 80.4) |

Maria checked: *"I have other retirement income," "good health with family longevity past 80,"* and *"want guaranteed income for as long as possible"* — three checks in the delay-favoring group. Maria's conclusion: *"Based on my numbers, I'm leaning toward claiming at 67, my Full Retirement Age, rather than 62 or 70 — it balances guaranteed income growth with not waiting the full 8 years to 70."*

**Based on the above, I'm currently leaning toward claiming at:** _____

> **A WORKING DECISION, NOT A FILED APPLICATION**
> You can revisit this page any time your situation changes before you actually apply.

PUTTING IT TOGETHER

# Action Checklist — What To Do Next

- [ ] Create or log into your mySocialSecurity account at ssa.gov/myaccount
- [ ] Confirm your official FRA benefit estimate (don't rely on old statements — check current)
- [ ] Run your numbers through the free Seniors Audit calculators: FRA, Break-Even, and (if married) Spousal Benefit calculators
- [ ] If married, complete Step 4 together with your spouse
- [ ] If still working and under FRA, review Step 5's earnings test
- [ ] Complete the Decision Worksheet in Step 6
- [ ] If you have a non-covered pension, confirm your benefit reflects the 2025 WEP/GPO repeal; for divorce or other complex situations, talk to a free SHIP counselor (shiphelp.org) or fee-only advisor
- [ ] Apply 1–3 months before your intended start date, online at ssa.gov/apply, by phone, or in person

REFERENCE

# Common Mistakes & Pro Tips

1. Assuming a spousal benefit is automatic. You generally need to actively apply for it — it isn't calculated and added without you requesting it.
2. Forgetting Social Security itself can be federally taxable. If your combined income (AGI + nontaxable interest + half your benefit) tops $25,000 single / $32,000 married, part of your benefit becomes taxable; above $34,000 / $44,000, up to 85% can be. This doesn't change your claiming-age math, but it affects your total retirement income planning.
3. Not checking survivor benefit impact before a lower earner claims early. If the higher earner claims early and passes away first, it can permanently lock in a smaller survivor benefit for the spouse who lives longer.
4. Assuming you can file a "restricted application" for just a spousal benefit while your own retirement benefit keeps growing. That option is gone for almost everyone claiming today — deemed filing applies to anyone born on or after January 2, 1954.
5. Applying without checking the earnings test first, if still working — an unexpected withholding surprise is avoidable with 5 minutes of checking Step 5.
6. Waiting to create a mySocialSecurity account until right before applying. Creating it early lets you monitor your actual earnings record for errors well before it affects your benefit calculation.

> **PRO TIP**
>
> If you're within a year of a claiming decision and unsure, request your official Social Security Statement by mail or download it from mySocialSecurity — it shows your real, personalized numbers at 62, FRA, and 70, more accurate than any generalized calculation once you're close to filing.

REFERENCE

# Questions to Ask a Professional

If you do talk to a financial advisor, tax professional, or SHIP counselor, these questions make the conversation more productive:

- ☐ Given my full financial picture, does delaying Social Security make sense for me?
- ☐ How would claiming at different ages affect my taxes in retirement?
- ☐ If I'm married, how does my claiming age affect my spouse's survivor benefit?
- ☐ If I have a pension from work not covered by Social Security, has my benefit been correctly recalculated under the 2025 WEP/GPO repeal?
- ☐ Should I coordinate my claiming age with required minimum distributions (RMDs) from retirement accounts?

REFERENCE

# How to Read the Confidence Markers

**LOW COMPLEXITY Straightforward**

Applies to most single filers with typical work histories.

**REVIEW CAREFULLY Moderate**

Marriage, survivor benefits, and continued work while claiming add real complexity.

**HIGH COMPLEXITY Get professional review**

Divorce, multiple marriages, disability transitions, or unusual/international work histories.

FINAL PAGE

# Sources & Update Information

- Full Retirement Age Chart — ssa.gov/benefits/retirement/planner/agereduction.html
- Early & Delayed Retirement Benefit Calculation — ssa.gov/oact/quickcalc/earlyretire.html
- Delayed Retirement Credits — ssa.gov/benefits/retirement/planner/delayret.html
- 2026 COLA, Earnings Limits & Taxable Maximum — ssa.gov/news/en/cola/index.html
- Social Security Fairness Act, Pub. L. 118-273 (WEP/GPO repeal, signed Jan. 5, 2025)
- Bipartisan Budget Act of 2015, Pub. L. 114-74, §831 (deemed filing rules)
- Create your mySocialSecurity account — ssa.gov/myaccount

Version: 2026.3 (revised — corrected break-even calculation, added 2025 WEP/GPO repeal update, deemed-filing guidance, and taxation thresholds) • Last reviewed: September 2026 • Next scheduled review: January 2027

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